Contrast and balance: although, whereas, however

Understand it

A balanced essay shows that you understand both sides before giving your view. Contrast words do this job, but they follow different grammar: some join two clauses, some start a new sentence, some are followed by a noun.

Using the wrong grammar after a contrast word is one of the most common band 6 errors. Learn each word with its pattern.

The rules

- although / even though + clause, clause: Although cars are convenient, they cause pollution.
- whereas / while join two opposite facts: Cars are fast, whereas bikes are healthy.
- However and on the other hand start a new sentence and are followed by a comma: Cars are fast. However, they are expensive.
- Despite / in spite of + noun or -ing: Despite the cost, many people buy cars.

All the words and forms you need

+ clause, + clause	although · even though · though · while · whereas
New sentence + comma	However, · Nevertheless, · Nonetheless, · On the other hand, · In contrast, · By contrast, · Conversely,
+ noun / -ing	despite · in spite of · regardless of
Inside one sentence	but · yet
Concession (admit a point)	Admittedly, · It is true that … but · While it is undeniable that …
Give your view	Personally, · On balance, · All things considered,

Where you use it

Writing: Discuss both views: Some people believe …, whereas others argue … Personally, I think …

Speaking: On the one hand … on the other hand … but overall I would say …

Reading: After However, the writer often gives the opposite point, which is the answer to many questions.

More examples

- While some argue that zoos protect animals, others believe they are cruel.
- Despite the high cost, many parents choose private schools.

- Cars are convenient. Nevertheless, they cause serious pollution.
- Admittedly, technology saves time, but it also creates stress.
- On balance, I believe the benefits outweigh the drawbacks.
- Young people prefer streaming, whereas older people still watch TV.

Common mistakes

Wrong	Right
✗ Although it is cheap, but I do not buy it.	✓ Although it is cheap, I do not buy it.
✗ Despite of the rain, we went.	✓ Despite the rain, we went.
✗ Cars are fast, however they are costly.	✓ Cars are fast; however, they are costly. (or a full stop before However)

Speaking practice: answer using this grammar

1. What are the good and bad sides of living in a city?
2. Do you prefer studying alone or in a group? Why not the other?
3. Is it better to have one close friend or many friends?
4. What are the advantages and disadvantages of tourism?
5. Should children wear school uniforms?

Writing practice

Write two sentences about working from home: one with whereas and one with despite.

Practice

1. Join with whereas: City life is fast. Village life is slow.

2. Rewrite with despite: Although it was expensive, he bought it.

3. Complete: Some argue that laws help. ___, others disagree.

4. Correct: Despite of the delay, we arrived.

5. Join with even though: She was ill. She worked.

6. Correct: Although it is hard, but it is useful.

Answers

1. City life is fast, whereas village life is slow.
2. Despite the high price, he bought it.
3. However / On the other hand
4. Despite the delay, we arrived.
5. Even though she was ill, she worked.
6. Although it is hard, it is useful.